There's less guesswork here; the square bracket notation `$myArray = []` always means an array, and the `new` keyword always denotes an instance of an object (in this case an instance of the PHP built-in `stdClass`). Arrays are covered in detail in Chapter 5, "Array," `stdClass` (and objects) are introduced in Chapter 6, "Object Fundamentals."

The Special (Resource) Type

```
$fh = fopen(__FILE__, "r");
var_dump($fh);
```

```
Output:
resource(5) of type (stream)
```

Here we're using the built-in `fopen()` function, which takes a filename (including path) and opens it (in this case for reading). The expression `__FILE__` is a built-in constant, which evaluates to the current file that contains the source code being executed. We'll look at constants properly in a moment.

The variable `$fh` is reported by `var_dump()` as being a stream `resource`, a special type that can be used to access a continuous stream of bytes. Resource types are increasingly rare in PHP due to the drive to replace them with dedicated built-in classes. As of PHP 8.2 `fopen()` (which will open files or network sockets – Linux-based systems use the filesystem to abstract all sorts of data exchange mechanisms, including network sockets) still returns a `stream` resource, but this will likely change in a future release of the language.

Forcing Type Changes

We've already seen PHP's type coercion mechanism demonstrated, showing how types would be converted automatically depending on the operation or call being made. I also mentioned it was possible to explicitly control type conversion. Here's how to do it:

```
$num = '123';
var_dump($num);
```

```
$num = (int) $num;
var_dump($num);
```